Where does applicant data go?

Invest Detroit Application Copilot · data-flow note for IT · November 2026 · Built and tested with made-up sample data only

APPLICANT'S DEVICE

1. The browser

- Applicant types answers and attaches files.
- **Review My Application runs here** (fixed rules, no AI, nothing sent).
- Files are checked only for type, size and empty files. **Their contents are never read or sent.**
- Builds the staff summary at Submit.
- Hides anything that looks like an SSN or account number before a chat question is sent.

Stored: a draft of the answers on this device only (no SSN, no files). It is deleted after 7 days, at Submit or on "Start over", and the applicant can turn it off.

chat question + which question they're on + last 6 chat messages

⇄

answer

COPILOT SERVER (RENDER, US)

2. Our small server

- Checks each question against the guardrails (off-topic, cheating, prompt tricks).
- Adds the AI's instructions and the knowledge base.
- Checks the answer before sending it back.
- Applies per-visitor and daily limits.

Stored: counts only, in a Render Postgres database, such as "review finding: loan > budget +1", "? pressed on Total budget +1", star ratings 1–5. Visitors are identified for limits by a salted hash of the IP address that changes daily. Invest Detroit collects these counts into its own system (export, webhook or page events).

Not stored: chat text, names, answers, files, raw IP addresses.

question (sensitive numbers removed) + instructions + knowledge base

⇄

answer + source ids

AI SERVICE (OPENAI MODELS)

3. The AI model

- Writes the chat answer: explains questions and terms.
- Invest Detroit facts (rates, fees, steps) only from the knowledge base, with sources.
- During the sprint: reached through the University of Michigan's GPT Toolkit gateway (a student class key). After handover: Invest Detroit's own OpenAI API account.
- Only used when `OPENAI_API_KEY` is set; without it nothing is sent.

Stored: we send requests with `store: false`; the provider's own API terms apply. OpenAI says API data isn't used for training by default. Check retention with your account before go-live.

INVEST DETROIT (AS TODAY)

4. FormAssembly ⇦ from 1, at Submit

The application, files and the staff summary (a hidden form field) go to Invest Detroit's existing form system, exactly as the form works today. **The copilot never receives them.**

What leaves Invest Detroit's systems because of the copilot

To our server (Render)	Chat questions, which question the applicant is on, their language, and counted events. Only the counts are kept.
To the AI service	Chat questions with SSN-like numbers removed, the last 6 chat messages, the question label, the language. Never form answers, files or names, unless the applicant types them into the chat.

Never leaves the applicant's browser through the copilot

Form answers	Go only to FormAssembly, as today.
Uploaded files	Never read or sent by the copilot.
SSN	Blocked from the chat; disabled in the prototype form.

Usage counts reach Invest Detroit's own system only through a token-protected export (USAGE_EXPORT_TOKEN), a signed webhook (USAGE_WEBHOOK_URL) or browser events on its own page; there is no dashboard. Keys live only in Render's Environment settings, never in the code (the repository is public). To switch the AI off at once, remove OPENAI_API_KEY; the chat keeps working from the built-in guide.